

PRISCILLA & AQUILA

Full Reference & Research — Everything Behind Today's Session, By Segment

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Everything read, researched, and referenced to build this session — not just what made it onto a slide. Organized by segment; within each segment, grouped by source. Where an item directly backs a specific slide, that's noted in parentheses (e.g. "Slide 17") — items without one are background/take-home-only, not part of the live talk. Take this home and dig in as deep as you want.

SEGMENT 1 — MEETING PRISCILLA & AQUILA

SCRIPTURE TEXTS

ACTS 18:1–4 — PAUL MEETS THEM IN CORINTH (Slides 6–7)

"After this Paul left Athens and went to Corinth. And he found a Jew named Aquila, a native of Pontus, recently come from Italy with his wife Priscilla, because Claudius had commanded all the Jews to leave Rome. And he went to see them, and because he was of the same trade he stayed with them and worked, for they were tentmakers by trade."

Paul arrives in Corinth alone and worn down after a brutal stretch of his second missionary journey. He finds a couple who share his trade and his faith — exactly what he needed at exactly the right moment.

ACTS 2:9; 1 PETER 1:1 — A POSSIBLE ORIGIN FOR AQUILA'S FAITH (THEORY) (Slide 8)

Acts 2:9 lists "residents of... Pontus" among those present at Pentecost. 1 Peter 1:1 is addressed "to those who are elect exiles... of Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia."

Aquila was from Pontus. It's plausible he came to faith either at Pentecost itself, or later through Peter's own ministry in that region — Scripture doesn't say definitively, but both are reasonable connections.

ACTS 16:10 — THE "WE" PASSAGES, AND WHY WE THINK LUKE STAYED IN PHILIPPI

"And when he had seen the vision, immediately we sought to go on into Macedonia, concluding that God had called us to preach the gospel to them."

This is the exact verse where Luke joins Paul's travels — and it's also where Acts' narration shifts from third-person ("they") to first-person plural ("we"). Most scholars read this as Luke, the author of Acts, signaling his own presence as an eyewitness from this point forward. Here's the part that matters for this session: the "we" language runs through the whole Philippi episode (16:10–40), then drops back to third-person ("he," "they") the moment Paul leaves Philippi — and doesn't pick "we" back up until Acts 20:5–6, years later, exactly when Paul passes back through Philippi again. The narrator's own presence tracks with the pronoun shift, which is why the standard

scholarly inference is that Luke didn't travel on with Paul from Philippi — he stayed behind, likely pastoring the young church there, for the years in between.

ACTS 18:18–19 — THEY FOLLOW PAUL TO EPHESUS (Slide 11)

"After this, Paul stayed many days longer and then took leave of the brothers and set sail for Syria, together with Priscilla and Aquila... And they came to Ephesus, and he left them there, but he himself went into the synagogue and reasoned with the Jews."

Paul had been blocked from entering Ephesus earlier by the Holy Spirit (Acts 16:6). A reasonable read: God was waiting until Paul could arrive alongside this couple.

1 CORINTHIANS 16:19; ROMANS 16:3–5; 2 TIMOTHY 4:19 — THEIR ONGOING MINISTRY (Slide 9)

"The churches of Asia send you greetings. Aquila and Prisca, together with the church in their house, send you hearty greetings in the Lord." (1 Cor. 16:19) ... "Greet Prisca and Aquila, my fellow workers in Christ Jesus, who risked their necks for my life, to whom not only I give thanks but all the churches of the Gentiles give thanks as well. Greet also the church in their house." (Rom. 16:3–5) ... "Greet Prisca and Aquila." (2 Tim. 4:19)

They host a church in their own home. Paul says they "risked their necks" for him — the specific incident isn't recorded, but the debt was real enough that "all the churches of the Gentiles" knew of it. They return to Rome once the ban on Jews lifts, then appear again later in Ephesus supporting Timothy — no home church mentioned at that point. Some scholars connect this to the Great Fire of Rome in AD 64: the persecution of Christians that followed (Nero blamed them for the fire) may have left the couple without a home to host in.

COMMENTARY & BACKGROUND

JAMES MONTGOMERY BOICE, COMMENTARY ON ACTS, PG. 303 — CORINTH'S REPUTATION (SLIDE 6)

"In the ancient world, the name 'Corinthian' was synonymous for the most perverted behavior... If you were called a 'Corinthian' in the ancient world (and were not actually from Corinth), you would regard that name as an insult." Paul doesn't just land in a random city after a brutal stretch of his journey — he lands in the ancient world's byword for moral corruption, and that's exactly where God has Priscilla and Aquila waiting for him.

A CAVEAT WORTH KNOWING (SLIDE 6)

Modern scholars note this reputation technically traces back to the OLDER Greek Corinth, which Rome leveled in 146 BC. The city Paul actually walks into was rebuilt from scratch as a Roman colony a century later — some argue the "sin city" label was an outdated stereotype by his day, not necessarily an accurate read on the rebuilt city itself. Doesn't change how Paul grew up hearing about it, though — the reputation shaped him regardless of whether it still fit the place he was walking into.

COMMENTARY NOTE (THEORY, NOT CERTAIN) — WAS PRISCILLA ROMAN NOBILITY? (SLIDE 10)

A minority but genuinely held theory. Her name follows the pattern of the *gens Prisca*, a Roman noble family, and she's listed first in most of Scripture's mentions of the couple — unusual for the era, and often read as a sign of higher social status. If the theory holds, she married Aquila, a Jewish laborer, across a real class line. Not certain — frame it as "some scholars believe," not settled fact.

COMMENTARY NOTE (MINORITY THEORY, NOT CONSENSUS) — WAS PRISCILLA THE AUTHOR OF HEBREWS?

Hebrews is anonymous — the author is never named in the text itself, which is unusual for a New Testament letter. Several scholars over the centuries (most notably Adolf von Harnack in the early 20th century) have proposed Priscilla as a candidate: the letter's polished rhetorical style fits someone well-versed in both Jewish and Greco-Roman argumentation, its author writes as someone with clear teaching authority recognized by the recipients, and one could argue anonymity itself might have been strategic given the cultural friction around a woman's name being attached to authoritative teaching. This is genuinely speculative — most scholars still favor other candidates (Paul, Apollos, Barnabas, Luke) — but it's a fascinating thread if you want to read further.

JOHN CHRYSOSTOM, HOMILY ON ROMANS 16:3 — "GREET PRISCILLA AND AQUILA"

John Chrysostom, a major early church father, wrote an entire homily devoted to this one couple — a strong ancient data point that Priscilla and Aquila were notable enough in the early church's memory to merit their own dedicated sermon, centuries after they lived.

SEGMENT 2 — PRISCILLA, AQUILA & APOLLOS / EPHESUS & ARTEMIS

SCRIPTURE TEXTS

ACTS 18:24–28 — CORRECTING APOLLOS (Slide 15)

"Now a Jew named Apollos, a native of Alexandria, came to Ephesus. He was an eloquent man, competent in the Scriptures... he began to speak boldly in the synagogue, but when Priscilla and Aquila heard him, they took him aside and explained to him the way of God more accurately."

Apollos was already a gifted, eloquent teacher — and still had an incomplete grasp of the gospel. Priscilla and Aquila, together, take him aside privately and correct him. Notice: not a public confrontation, a private and respectful one.

1 TIMOTHY 2:9-15 — FULL PASSAGE (Slide 17)

"Likewise also that women should adorn themselves in respectable apparel, with modesty and self-control, not with braided hair and gold or pearls or costly attire, but with what is proper for women who profess godliness — with good works. Let a woman learn quietly with all submissiveness. I do not permit a woman to teach or to exercise authority over a man; rather, she is to remain quiet. For Adam was formed first, then Eve; and Adam was not deceived, but the woman was deceived and became a transgressor. Yet she will be saved through childbearing — if they continue in faith and love and holiness, with self-control."

The hardest verse of the day, and the passage the rest of this segment's research is aimed at understanding in context.

ACTS 19:23–41 — THE RIOT OVER ARTEMIS (Slide 22)

"About that time there arose no little disturbance concerning the Way. For a man named Demetrius, a silversmith, who made silver shrines of Artemis, brought no little business to the craftsmen... The city was filled with the confusion, and they rushed together into the theater..."

Ephesus was home to the massive temple and cult of Artemis, where women held real religious and civic authority. Paul's instructions to this specific church were arguably counter-cultural in the opposite direction most readers assume — correcting a disordered authority structure, not suppressing women broadly.

1 TIMOTHY 5:13-14; 2 TIMOTHY 3:6-9 — BUSYBODIES, MAGIC, AND MARRIAGE ADVICE (Slide 28)

"...they learn to be idlers, going about from house to house, and not only idlers, but also gossips and busybodies, saying what they should not... I would have younger widows marry, bear children, manage their households..." (1 Tim. 5:13-14) ... "For among them are those who creep into households and capture weak women, burdened with sins and led astray by various passions... these men oppose the truth, men corrupted in mind and disqualified regarding the faith. But they will not get very far, for their folly will be plain to all, as was that of those two men." (2 Tim. 3:6-9)

Some scholars read "busybodies" in 1 Timothy 5:13 as a term for practicing magic, not gossip — Ephesus had a real, documented history with it (Paul's own ministry there ends with a mass book-burning of magic scrolls, Acts 19:18-19). If that reading holds, some women bringing old practices into the church may be the same underlying issue behind both this verse and 1 Timothy 2:12's "exercise authority." The unnamed "two men" in 2 Timothy 3:8 are Jannes and Jambres, figures from Jewish magical tradition — another thread tying this letter-group back to a magic-saturated environment.

KEENER — ACTS: AN EXEGETICAL COMMENTARY

KEENER, PG. 2713 — NAME ORDER AND STATUS (Slide 16)

"Paul once and Luke twice (out of three times) refers to Prisca before her husband. Normally the husband was named first unless the wife was of higher social status... She may have exercised a higher status in the Christian community or in their ministry... it was at least known and respected in the church."

This is the scholarly backing behind "Priscilla is named first most of the time" — not just an observation, a documented ancient-world convention.

KEENER, PG. 2809 — LUKE'S OWN NAMING CONVENTION (Slide 16)

Talbert, cited in Keener: name-sequence flips (citing Acts 13:2, 7, 13, 50, among others) apply 'to Priscilla as 'the dominant religious authority' of the two.'

The strongest single textual evidence for this: Luke uses the exact same name-order convention on Barnabas and Paul — switching from "Barnabas and Saul" to "Paul and Barnabas" at exactly the point Paul steps into leadership, Acts 13 — then applies that identical convention to Priscilla over Aquila. That's not an outside inference — it's demonstrably how Luke writes when he wants to signal a shift in who's leading.

KEENER, PG. 2809 — ANCIENT SCRIBES NOTICED, TOO

"An ancient reader might find something unusual here... the Western text... displays a fairly consistent 'antifeminist' tendency; in this context, it omits Priscilla in Acts 18:3, 18, 21 and places Aquila's name before hers in this verse, ensuring that its readers will assume his leadership."

Real manuscript evidence, not modern inference — ancient scribes were uncomfortable enough with Priscilla's prominence to edit her out in some manuscript traditions. Multiple named scholars document this (Witherington has a paper literally titled "Anti-feminist Tendencies"; Bart Ehrman covers it too).

KEENER, PG. 2811 — AMMONIUS PRAISED APOLLOS FOR THIS

Citing Ammonius, an early commentator: even in antiquity, some voices praised Apollos specifically *for* his willingness to be taught by a woman — not scandalized by it, impressed by it.

WEBB — SLAVES, WOMEN & HOMOSEXUALS

WEBB, PG. 99 — PRISCILLA NAMED AS WEBB'S OWN "BREAKOUT" EXAMPLE (*HANDOUT ONLY* — *NOT PART OF THE LIVE TALK*)

"What provides a breakout from patriarchy is Priscilla's dominant ministry role in relationship to her husband... She is at least a co-leader, and probably a primary leader, in the process of church planting and evangelism... Priscilla is likely the major participant, as indicated by name order, in the correction and instruction of the male preacher, Apollos."

A second scholar, independent of Keener and Talbert, making the same name-order-as-leadership argument — and pushing further than this session's live framing into explicit "primary/dominant leader" language.

HOAG — WEALTH IN ANCIENT EPHEBUS AND THE FIRST LETTER TO TIMOTHY

HOAG, PG. 75, 79 — THE HAIRSTYLE CONNECTION (Slide 23)

"This word appears to point to a hairstyle that was closely associated with the goddess, Artemis, in this social setting... As Anthia led the procession as Artemis, πεπλεγμένη is the term used by Xenophon of Ephesus to describe her coiffure."

1 Timothy 2:9's hair instruction (πλέγμασιν) shares a root with the word used for the hairstyle worn in Ephesus's Artemis processions — confirmed against the primary ancient source, Xenophon's *Ephesiaca* 1.2.6. Flagged as Hoag's own research contribution, not broad scholarly consensus.

HOAG, PG. 89, 92 — THE DISPUTED WORD, AND WHAT *EPHESIACA* ACTUALLY SHOWS (Slides 26-27)

Wilshire, cited in Hoag: "Wilshire explored the 314 or so instances of αὐθεντεῖν in antiquity using TLG... he rendered αὐθεντεῖν 'exercise authority' and then later determined 'instigating violence' may be more accurate." And, on the primary source itself: "The learning setting as illustrated in Ephesiaca for women in Ephesus is not depicted as quiet, and women do not take a submissive posture... they take a fiercely competitive rather than humbly submissive posture to vie for different priestess roles."

Two separate points worth keeping distinct. First: the actual Greek word behind "exercise authority" in 1 Timothy 2:12 is genuinely contested — even the leading word-study scholar landed on two different readings over time. Second: the ancient novel *Ephesiaca* itself shows women in a competitive, assertive religious posture — real and well-sourced, separate from the stronger claim below.

KROEGER — THE DISPUTED "CULTIC DOMINANCE" CLAIM

WHAT STAYS OUT OF THE LIVE TALK

Richard and Catherine Kroeger, cited in Hoag pg. 86: Ephesus may have been a matriarchal society where women had a "monopoly on religious power," sourced to Strabo's claim that women could "receive oracles and attain priesthoods." This is a real, named scholarly theory — but it's directly disputed by other classicists (Marg Mowczko, S.M. Baugh), who report finding no ancient source supporting the idea that Ephesian women saw themselves as superior because of Artemis. The more modest, uncontested point (women held real priestess/religious office, and *Ephesiaca* shows them in a competitive posture) is used live; this stronger "cultic dominance explains Paul's word choice" claim doesn't hold up as well, so it's parked here instead.

GLAHN — NOBODY'S MOTHER: ARTEMIS OF THE EPHESIANS

THE EPHEBUS BOOK LIST (SLIDE 21)

Confirmed: 1 Corinthians (FROM Ephesus), 1 & 2 Timothy (TO Ephesus), Ephesians, Revelation (Ephesus is literally the first of its seven churches). Strong-argument, one reason each: John's Gospel/letters (early tradition places John in Ephesus post-Patmos); Titus (Crete shared a strikingly similar religious/cultural backdrop); Philippians, Colossians, and Philemon (a real minority theory holds these were written from an Ephesian imprisonment, not only Paul's Roman one).

PLINY, STRABO, CALLIMACHUS, PAUSANIAS — EPHEBUS'S FAME AND THE AMAZON-FOUNDING LEGEND (Slide 22)

Pausanias, Description of Greece 4.31.8: "all cities worship Artemis of Ephesus, and individuals hold her in honor above all the gods."

Three independent ancient sources connect Ephesus's founding to the Amazons, and archaeology backs up the city's self-identification with them. Ancient sources rank Artemis of Ephesus the second-most-titled deity in the entire Greek pantheon, behind only Zeus. Her temple: four times the size of the Parthenon, 127 sixty-foot columns — one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World.

GLAHN — THE VIRGIN GODDESS OF CHILDBIRTH PARADOX (Slide 24)

Artemis's own origin myth explains the paradox at the heart of 1 Timothy 2:15: she was present at her twin brother Apollo's birth and, according to legend, helped deliver him — making her, ever after, both a perpetual virgin and the goddess women turned to for safe delivery. Glahn's own synthesis: Artemis offered either a painless delivery, or a painless death if delivery went wrong. That's the exact danger 1 Timothy 2:15 is speaking into. (This also

corrects a common modern misconception that Artemis was a "man-hater" — her cult was about protection in a specific danger, not hostility toward men generally.)

GLAHN, PG. 128 — THE STANDOUT OF THE WHOLE RESEARCH BATCH

Paul gives Corinthian widows the opposite marital advice he gives Ephesian widows — "consider remaining unmarried" to Corinth (1 Cor 7:8), but "marry and bear children" (*teknogonein*) to Ephesus (1 Tim 5:14) — the same word root that shows up in 1 Timothy 2:15's "saved through childbearing" (*teknogonias*). Given the Artemis cult's own veneration of virginity, Paul's advice to Ephesian widows may be a deliberate counter-cultural move: godliness doesn't require imitating the reigning local ideal of staying unmarried. This is probably the strongest single piece of evidence in the whole session that Paul's instructions were situational, not universal — the same apostle gives opposite advice to two different cities, for reasons tied directly to each city's own culture.

Worth knowing: this doesn't actually conflict with Segment 3's singleness material (1 Cor 7:7-8). Paul's preference for singleness there is framed in terms of undivided devotion to ministry (1 Cor 7:32-35) — a timeless, personal-calling argument. The Corinth-vs-Ephesus widow instructions are a narrower, different question: what's protective and wise for a specific widow in a specific city, given that city's specific pressures.

GLAHN — ARTEMIS AS A GODDESS OF VENGEANCE (SLIDE 22)

Beyond childbirth, Artemis carried real pastoral and emotional stakes for her worshippers — myth also cast her as a goddess capable of vengeance against those who slighted her. Leaving her behind for Christ wasn't a neutral consumer choice for an Ephesian convert; it carried real, felt spiritual risk.

TWO CORRECTIONS WORTH KNOWING

Artemis is not tied to cult prostitution — no ancient source says so, despite the common modern assumption (often bleeding over from Corinth's own, separately disputed reputation). And the famous "many-breasted" statue of Artemis of Ephesus is very likely armor or ornamentation, not anatomy — the same rounded objects appear on statues of male gods too.

GLAHN — REAL CIVIC AND RELIGIOUS OFFICE HELD BY EPHESIAN WOMEN (Slide 29)

Epigraphic (inscription) evidence documents actual civic and religious titles held by women in Ephesus — priestess roles, and even titles like *prytanis* (a senior civic magistrate office) and *gymnasiarch* (overseer of the city's gymnasium/education institution). Kept explicitly separate from the disputed "cultic dominance" claim above — not a claim that women ran Ephesus, just documented evidence that real civic and religious offices were genuinely open to and held by women there, shaping the cultural water everyone in that church was swimming in.

ARNOLD — EPHESUS'S DOCUMENTED HISTORY WITH MAGIC (SLIDE 28)

Clinton Arnold's research on Ephesus documents just how saturated the city was with magical practice — consistent with Acts 19:18-19's mass burning of magic scrolls after Paul's ministry there. Pietersen's

reading of 1 Timothy 5:13's "busybodies" (*periergoi/perierga*) as a term specifically for magic practice, not idle gossip, fits this same backdrop.

GLAHN — PAUL'S TITLES FOR GOD ECHO AND SUBVERT ARTEMIS'S OWN TITLES (Slide 24)

Paul's title choices for God and Jesus across 1 Timothy directly echo — and then subvert — titles Artemis herself carried in Ephesus. Most notably: "Savior" clusters almost exclusively in the Ephesus/Crete-connected letters (Titus, 1 Timothy, and Ephesians 5:23 itself — inside the very marriage passage Segment 3 is built around) and is nearly absent everywhere else Paul writes. One of Artemis's own titles was "Savior." Paul's sharpened point, in Glahn's reading: not a passive echo, an active confrontation — Artemis is not our Savior, Jesus is.

GLAHN — "ADAM WAS FORMED FIRST" AS A COUNTER-CLAIM (Slide 25)

Being firstborn was literally one of Artemis's own titles — a claim to preeminence and autonomy, since she was present at her twin Apollo's birth. Read against that backdrop, "Adam was formed first" (1 Timothy 2:13) may not be staking a claim to one-sided male authority — it may be restoring interdependence against a culture that used being-first as a status claim. A possible second angle: early church fathers (Irenaeus, Tertullian) identify an incipient Gnostic heresy at Ephesus — the Kroegers' research argues some of it claimed Eve was actually made first, an "originator" with special status. If real, Paul may be correcting that specific local claim directly.

GLAHN — THREE EXPLANATORY ANGLES FOR "I DO NOT PERMIT A WOMAN TO TEACH" (Slides 28-29)

Religious/magic: the issue may connect to Ephesus's magic-saturated environment (see above).

Financial/patronage (speculative, per Glahn's own hedge): the Artemis cult was famous for wealthy female benefactors, and the early church leaned on generous women too — old leverage habits may have followed some women into the church. Roman civil law (real historical precedent, from Bruce Winter's *Roman Wives, Roman Widows*, pg. 93): an imperial ban existed from the time of Augustus on women intervening on behalf of others in a legal/public setting — meaning the wider Roman culture already restricted women's public advocacy, which may explain Paul's instruction as declining to make the church needlessly stranger than its surroundings, not only a theological stance.

ONE CONTINUOUS, TWO-SIDED PASSAGE (SLIDE 30)

1 Timothy 2:8's correction to angry, quarreling men pairs directly with 2:11's correction to disruptive women — read together, it looks like one continuous instruction to a whole unruly congregation, not women singled out. This also extends the αἰθεντεῖν word study above with two more scholars (Hubner, Westfall) landing on similarly aggressive readings ("dominate," "usurp," even "instigating violence") for the disputed word behind "exercise authority."

TWO STANDING CAVEATS

The Danvers Statement (1987) is the real modern document most complementarian teaching on this passage traces back to — useful to know by name if this comes up in conversation. And a caution worth applying to all of the above (Trebilco): "Ephesian Artemis" and the more generic pan-Greek Artemis known from Homer, Hesiod, and Callimachus are similar, but substantially different — the myth

material above describes the wider Artemis tradition Ephesus inherited and adapted, not a perfect one-to-one match with Ephesus's own local cult practice.

SEGMENT 3 — MARRIAGE, SUBMISSION & ONENESS

SCRIPTURE TEXTS

EPHESIANS 5:18B–22 — SUBMITTING TO ONE ANOTHER (Slides 34, 36)

"...addressing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody to the Lord with your heart, giving thanks always and for everything to God the Father in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ. Wives, submit to your own husbands, as to the Lord."

Verse 22 does not begin a new topic — it continues directly from verse 21's call for the whole church to submit to one another. The instruction to wives sits inside a broader call to mutual submission, not apart from it.

EPHESIANS 5:25–29 — HUSBANDS, LOVE YOUR WIVES (Slide 34)

"Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her... In the same way husbands should love their wives as their own bodies. He who loves his wife loves himself. For no one ever hated his own flesh, but nourishes and cherishes it, just as Christ does the church."

The instruction to wives (submit) is paired with a far heavier instruction to husbands (love sacrificially, as Christ loved the church). Paul even makes a self-interested case for it: you cannot hurt your wife without hurting yourself, since the two are joined.

EPHESIANS 5:32 — THE MYSTERY (Slide 34)

"This mystery is profound, and I am saying that it refers to Christ and the church."

Paul's own conclusion to the marriage passage: every Godly marriage is ultimately a small, lived picture of something much bigger — Christ's relationship to the church.

GENESIS 2:24 — THE TWO BECOME ONE (Slide 42)

"Therefore a man shall leave his father and his mother and hold fast to his wife, and they shall become one flesh."

The oldest marriage text in Scripture, and the goal underneath both submission and love: not just cohabitation, but genuine oneness.

GALATIANS 3:28 — NEITHER MALE NOR FEMALE (Slide 36)

"There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free, there is no male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus."

Real tension worth sitting with, not a contradiction to resolve away: if God makes no distinction for gender, why does Paul make one in Ephesians 5?

DEUTERONOMY 25:5-10 — LEVIRATE MARRIAGE (Slides 39-40)

"If brothers dwell together, and one of them dies and has no son, the wife of the dead man shall not be married outside the family to a stranger. Her husband's brother shall go in to her and take her as his wife and perform the duty of a husband's brother to her... And if the man does not wish to take his brother's wife... his brother's wife shall go up to him in the presence of the elders and pull his sandal off his foot and spit in his face."

Sounds backwards today. At the time, it was genuinely protective: women couldn't reliably earn income, were vulnerable without a husband's protection, and children carried real social and spiritual weight. Not redemptive today — the vulnerabilities it addressed have largely changed.

1 CORINTHIANS 9:22 — WHY PAUL WROTE WHAT HE WROTE (Slide 41)

"I have become all things to all people, that I might by all means save some."

Paul could have pushed the church toward a more countercultural marital ethic. He chose the priority of reconciling people to God over social revolution.

ROMANS 8:38-39 — WHAT TRANSCENDS CULTURE (Slide 37)

"For I am sure that neither death nor life, nor angels nor rulers, nor things present nor things to come, nor powers, nor height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus our Lord."

A useful contrast point: this is what a truly timeless, uncultured command sounds like — true everywhere, always, the same way Ephesians 5:21's mutual-submission command is.

1 CORINTHIANS 11:11-12 — MUTUAL DEPENDENCE

"Nevertheless, in the Lord woman is not independent of man nor man of woman; for as woman was made from man, so man is now born of woman. And all things are from God."

New scripture territory for this session — not referenced elsewhere in the talk. Webb's read: the equality and mutual dependence stated plainly here calls into question a purely hierarchical reading of the surrounding material in that same letter.

JOHN 5:30; LUKE 22:42 — JESUS AND SUBMISSION

"I can do nothing on my own. As I hear, I judge, and my judgment is just, because I seek not my own will but the will of him who sent me." (John 5:30) ... "Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done." (Luke 22:42)

Submission, modeled by the Son toward the Father — not out of weakness or inferiority, but out of trust.

JOHN 14:10; MARK 1:11; JOHN 10:30 — JESUS AND ONENESS

"Do you not believe that I am in the Father and the Father is in me?" (John 14:10) ... "You are my beloved Son; with you I am well pleased." (Mark 1:11) ... "I and the Father are one." (John 10:30)

The same relationship that models submission also models total oneness. The two pillars are not in tension with each other — they're companions.

1 CORINTHIANS 10:23 — CONTEXT AND APPLICATION

"All things are lawful,' but not all things are helpful. 'All things are lawful,' but not all things build up."

A useful lens for reading Paul's letters generally — his instructions are often shaped by the specific situation of a specific church, not issued as timeless abstractions detached from context.

PHILIPPIANS 4:13 — STRENGTH FOR THE HARDER THING

"I can do all things through him who strengthens me."

Used here as a challenge, not a general-purpose motivational verse: whichever of the two pillars is harder for you personally, this is the resource for pursuing it anyway.

WEBB & STACKHOUSE — THE METHOD: HERMENEUTICS & THE REDEMPITIVE-MOVEMENT FRAMEWORK

WILLIAM J. WEBB, *SLAVES, WOMEN & HOMOSEXUALS*, PG. 21 — THE FISH AND THE WATER (Slide 20)

"Most of us are oblivious to the culture around us. Like the air we breathe, it is invisible and we simply take it for granted... One could ask the question of a fish, 'Is your nose wet?' ... If fish were scientists, probably the last thing they would discover is water! So it is with us. We live and move about in the culture with which we are closely and invisibly enmeshed."

Step one before touching any of the actual gender texts: we read Scripture assuming we're neutral observers of it, and we're not — we're as blind to our own cultural water as the original audience was to theirs.

WEBB, PG. 22-23 — COUNTERCULTURE, PARACULTURE, AND PAUL'S OWN EXAMPLE (Slide 41)

"Should I act counterculturally or paraculturally in my life?... It is necessary for Christians to challenge their culture where it departs from kingdom values; it is equally necessary for them to identify with their culture on all other matters." And: "The apostle's Magna Carta of cultural sensitivity might be found in his words, 'I have become all things to all people, that I might by all means save some' (1 Cor 9:22)."

The actual operative question for how a Christian reads and lives inside a culture — and Webb roots it directly in Paul's own words, the same 1 Corinthians 9:22 quote used live in this segment.

WEBB, PG. 50 — WHAT A REDEMPTIVE-MOVEMENT HERMENEUTIC ACTUALLY CLAIMS (Slide 38)

"A redemptive-movement hermeneutic argues for a balanced perspective — one that wrestles with left-side implications as well as right-side implications. It is not, as some critics have said, that Scripture is repressive or sexist regarding slaves and women. That is to talk about Scripture in a vacuum, devoid of its original setting or cultural backdrop... Relative to when and where the words of Scripture were first read, they spoke redemptively to their given communities. Yet, to stay with the isolated words of the text instead of their spirit leads to an equally tragic misreading."

Probably the single most important quote in this whole document. It answers the objection likely to come up first: "isn't this just calling the Bible sexist?" No — the opposite move. The text was redemptive when it was written; the mistake is freezing the letter of it in place instead of carrying its spirit forward into a culture that's moved past the specific problem it was solving.

WEBB, PG. 57-59 — REALISM, THE ELASTIC BAND, AND THE PASTOR'S HEART (Slide 41)

"...a redemptive-movement hermeneutic highlights a wonderful blend of realism and idealism within Scripture. The Christian who embraces a redemptive-spirit approach cannot help but be profoundly influenced by the resilient character of the ancient text as it continues to speak to our modern world." (pg. 57) "Biblical texts often represent pastoral letters, written with the tenderness of a pastor's heart. Their words are designed to 'stretch' the covenant people as far as they could go, like an elastic band, but not to cause them to 'snap'." (pg. 58) "In moving people toward a particular goal, wise pastors will gently and lovingly shepherd their people along at a pace that they can handle. A well-seasoned pastor understands that one cannot change another person's worldview overnight." (pg. 59)

Three pages forming one arc — tension, image, application. Scripture stretches people as far as they can go without snapping them, the way a wise pastor paces real change in real people rather than demanding it overnight.

WEBB, PG. 60 — EACH GENERATION, STARTING OVER

"With each generation, in a sense God has had to start over in moving a new group of people toward his redemptive goals. The author of Hebrews laments that many in his congregation are still struggling with the basics of their Christian faith and are slow to learn (Heb 5:11-6:3)... The level at which a teacher chooses to teach is directly related to the level of his or her audience."

WEBB, PG. 61 — A HEIGHTENED STANDARD FOR TEACHERS

Both Old and New Testaments hold a heightened expectation for priests, elders, deacons, and teachers generally (e.g., 1 Tim 3:1-13; Titus 1:6-9; James 3:1; Luke 20:45-47) — teachers within the covenant community bear a greater responsibility for their actions than the congregation at large.

WEBB, PG. 61 — JESUS'S OWN REDEPTIVE-MOVEMENT READING, MATTHEW 5

"The use of a redemptive-movement hermeneutic may also be seen in Jesus' approach to Scripture in Matthew 5... In each case he quotes the biblical tradition, 'It has been said...' and then moves to what he understands as a redemptive better, 'But I tell you...' As a new Moses, Jesus leads his community to a heightened ethic beyond their old law code."

Jesus himself models this exact reading pattern in the Sermon on the Mount — taking the tradition as a floor, not a ceiling, and moving it forward. Pairs directly with Stackhouse's material below on Jesus and cultural distinctions.

FAIR NAMING OF THE OTHER SIDE

Webb, pg. 45: "Now, it is understandable why certain Christians and evangelical scholars do not want to propose a social ethic... that exceeds (in realized form) the ethics of Scripture. It is likely that they think such a view impugns the testimony of the biblical witness." This isn't a strawman being knocked down — some genuinely thoughtful people think "the redemptive arc can keep moving past what the text explicitly says" is itself a dangerous move, and that concern isn't crazy. Better to engage it than pretend it doesn't exist.

JOHN G. STACKHOUSE JR., *PARTNERS IN CHRIST*, PG. 10 — HOW, NOT JUST WHAT

"If we're in a debate over a Christian view of gender with someone who is not serious about Jesus... we have to have a different kind of debate... We can and we must, however, presume good will, and goodwill of the most basic Christian sort: we're trying to follow Jesus. You are. I am."

The tone to bring into this — not just what's being discussed, but how. De-charge it, and try to actually follow Jesus together rather than win an argument.

STACKHOUSE, PG. 14 — WORKING DEFINITION OF "FEMINIST"

"I recognize that the noun 'feminist' can mean several things, but this is what I mean by it: someone who champions the dignity, rights, responsibilities, and glories of women as equal in importance to those of men, and who therefore refuses discrimination against women."

A deliberate working definition to use if the word comes up, rather than letting the room supply its own — likely more loaded — version of it.

STACKHOUSE, PG. 19 — WHY WE NEED MORE THAN A SURFACE READING

"God gave his people teachers, as the Bible itself affirms precisely because much of the Bible is not easily understood... Ah, now we need something more than childlike faith: we need adult reflection."

Pairs with the Webb fish/water quote above — a second way into the same idea from a different author.

STACKHOUSE, PG. 22, 33 — THE ACTUAL THESIS

"It seems to me that the burden of proof falls on the complementarians. They are obliged to show how it is really better for subordination to continue to characterize the relationship of Christian men and women..." And, framed as the case for the other side: "What has not been made clear in the current debate... is just why God would want that, when he seems... to have made women evidently quite capable of leadership in all other spheres of society... God seems to have good reasons for his other commands; what is his good reason for this one?"

These are Stackhouse's actual argued position, not neutral background. He's making a case, not just describing a debate — worth knowing going in, so this doesn't get presented as more neutral than it is.

STACKHOUSE, PG. 45 — HIS OWN STATED POSITION

"I propose, then, a paradigm of gender that does, indeed, draw no lines between men and women as to role in home, church, or society beyond those required by biology."

Stackhouse's bottom line, in his own words. The "biology" carve-out is his one stated boundary.

STACKHOUSE — GOD WORKS WITH WHAT HE'S GOT

STACKHOUSE, PG. 52 — THE CORE HERMENEUTICAL MOVE (Slide 38)

"To be blunt, God works with what he's got — and with what we've got. When faced with our shortcomings and sin, God doesn't just erase us and create a whole new situation. Instead, God graciously pursues shalom in the glory and the mess that we have made."

The backbone of the whole redemptive-arc argument: God accommodates and works within a fallen structure (like patriarchy) toward something better, rather than either endorsing it as the ideal or blowing it up outright.

STACKHOUSE, PG. 52-53 — JESUS AND CULTURAL DISTINCTIONS

"We encounter the apparent scandal of Jesus not healing everyone, or delivering everyone from captivity, or raising everyone from the dead... it was somehow more strategic for Jesus to limit his array of miracles... In just this way, I suggest, Jesus puts critical and creative pressure against gender distinction of his culture — the way he also does against the Jew/Gentile distinction, against the Jew/Samaritan distinction, against the rich/poor distinction, and so on — but without going so far as to actually overturn it."

Jesus pressures cultural distinctions without fully overturning them in His own ministry — the same pattern Webb describes above (counterculture where it matters most, paraculture elsewhere), now grounded specifically in how Jesus operated.

A GUARDRAIL WORTH KEEPING

Stackhouse, pg. 53: "The main scandal of Jesus' career is properly Jesus — not Jesus and feminism, or Jesus and the abolition of slavery, or Jesus and Jewish emancipation, or anything else." A deliberate check against overstating the point. The goal isn't to make Jesus into a 21st-century cause. The gospel stays the headline.

STACKHOUSE & GLAHN — WHY THE APOSTLES WROTE AS THEY DID

STACKHOUSE, PG. 56 — GOSPEL PRIORITIES OVER SOCIAL REVOLUTION (Slide 41)

"It would make sense — given gospel priorities, holy pragmatism, and eschatological expectations — for the apostles to teach a policy of cultural conservatism ('Get along as best you can with the political power and social structures that be') in the interest of accomplishing the one crucial task: spreading the gospel as far and as fast as possible. And they do."

The apostles didn't preach social upheaval partly because they expected the end was near and trusted God to sort it out in the new Kingdom — so work with what you've got, and keep the main priority the main priority: bringing people to God.

BRUCE WINTER, *ROMAN WIVES, ROMAN WIDOWS*, PG. 93, CITED IN GLAHN, PG. 135 — A CONCRETE EPHESUS-SPECIFIC EXAMPLE

"Women were not to intervene (intercede) in public settings nor come between two parties, and [an] imperial ban already existed from the time of Augustus on women intervening on behalf of their husbands in the context of a legal argument."

Gives the "cultural conservatism" argument above a concrete, non-hypothetical anchor: an actual Roman imperial law, on the books since Augustus, restricting women's public legal advocacy. If the wider culture already saw women "exercising authority" in public disputes as inappropriate or illegal, Paul's instruction may reflect a deliberate choice not to make the church needlessly stranger than its surroundings — an evangelistic consideration, not only a theological one.

STACKHOUSE, PG. 67 — PAUL DOING TWO THINGS AT ONCE

"I suggest that Paul is guided by the Holy Spirit — even used by the Holy Spirit perhaps without his full awareness of the implications — to do two good things simultaneously: (1) to give the church prudent instruction as to how to survive and thrive in a patriarchal culture that he thinks won't last long, and also (2) to maintain and promote egalitarian teaching

that is evident throughout the Bible and dynamic particularly in the career of Jesus and that in the right circumstances will leave gender lines behind."

Probably the clearest single-sentence thesis in the whole batch, tying directly back to the actual tension Segment 2 is built around: Priscilla teaching Apollos, sitting right next to Paul's instruction in 1 Timothy 2:12. Same apostle, same tension — this is Stackhouse's proposed resolution.

A CONCRETE TEXTUAL EXAMPLE — 1 CORINTHIANS

Stackhouse, pg. 67: "Paul seems to believe that women should keep silence in church and that they should pray and prophesy. And this apparent contradiction appears in passages occurring in the very same letter, 1 Corinthians. How could women possibly obey him in both respects? By being silent at the right times, and praying and prophesying at the right times." (Likely 1 Corinthians 11:5 alongside 14:34.)

STACKHOUSE, PG. 68 — WHY NOT LEADERSHIP, BUT YES TO PRAYER AND PROPHECY

"Women were not trained to exercise such public leadership over mixed groups, and society was not trained to accept it." And: "Public prayer and prophecy, however, do not require formal education. Paul therefore not only allows but actually seems to expect women to engage in such edifying discourse. Thus his only advice to them on this matter is again to avoid unnecessary scandal..."

If Paul had endorsed women's public leadership back then, it likely would have failed outright — there was no support system to equip women for it, and the surrounding culture would have rejected it wholesale. Those specific limitations aren't present the same way today.

STACKHOUSE & WEBB — POWER REFRAMED AS STEWARDSHIP

STACKHOUSE, PG. 74 — THE BRIDGE INTO MARRIAGE (Slide 41)

"The same dynamic is true in the husband and wife relationship. In a social situation in which the husband has substantially more power — social, intellectual, political, and financial — because patriarchal society has awarded it to him simply on the basis of his sex, then he should use that power the way all of God's people are supposed to use whatever power they have received: on behalf of others, as imitators of the God who graciously cares for us."

The pivot from the church-leadership discussion into marriage specifically — really the point of this whole session. Power reframed as stewardship, not entitlement.

WEBB, PG. 80 — WHAT PAUL DOES NOT SAY (Slide 41)

"Paul commands wives to 'submit.' Correspondingly, he does not command husbands to 'rule' or 'lead' (the reciprocal imperative to submit) but to 'love.' The husband's rule or authority is

assumed in the discussion, but softened considerably through Paul's altered focus... Paul assumes the status quo for women; however, he pushes the boundaries for men with the direction of his command."

The sharpest, most citable version of the "power reframed as stewardship" point, applied directly to Ephesians 5. Used live in Segment 3's "Reading Ephesians 5 Now" beat.

WEBB, PG. 83 — "SEED IDEAS"

"A component of a text may be cultural if 'seed ideas' are present within the rest of Scripture to suggest and encourage further movement on a particular subject... the seed idea describes something at an early stage. It is in seedling form, not fully developed." Same concept as "seeds of emancipation" below, from a second author.

STACKHOUSE, PG. 77-78 — "SEEDS OF EMANCIPATION"

"It is better to see this passage in parallel with slaveholding and parenting. Society has already awarded power to masters, parents, and husbands... Paul does not advise a domestic revolution... but instead commands Christians to ameliorate these exercises of power as far as they can. And, along the way, the Holy Spirit inspires him to plant seeds of emancipation that blossom when the time is right." And: "So long as you are the stronger member of any relationship... use that strength on behalf of the weaker; so long as you are the weaker... it is best to submit to the stronger. The fact that you occupy a particular social role currently, however, implies nothing about whether that role is legitimate or about whether you will remain in it indefinitely."

Probably the clearest single statement of the whole argument Segment 3 is built around — ties together "God works with what he's got," "cultural conservatism for the gospel's sake," and "power as stewardship" into one line. The masters/slaves, parents/children, husbands/wives parallel is deliberate on Stackhouse's part, not something read into it.

STACKHOUSE, PG. 123 — A MODERN ILLUSTRATION

"I think of a brilliant alumna who serves as a missionary with her husband in a Muslim-majority nation. She is every bit the feminist I am, but she sits in the back seat of their car, veils her head, walks behind her husband and in all other respects — 'stupid, but trivial, respects,' she calls them — conforms with the patriarchal customs of that culture in order to focus her neighbors' attention on their sharing of Jesus and the gospel, and not on disruptive Christian views of gender equality. 'First things first,' she says."

A real, modern example of someone making the same strategic call Paul's letters describe the apostles making — by choice, not by law.

WEBB, PG. 84 — GALATIANS 3:28 HAS REAL SOCIAL IMPLICATIONS (SLIDE 36)

"Once Galatians 3:28 is set within the broader corpus of Pauline theology, there is no question that the 'in Christ' formula has social implications. This is immediately evident in the relationship between Jews and Gentiles." Strengthens the Galatians 3:28 tension already central to this segment's live material.

WEBB, PG. 128 — *EZER* ("HELPER") WORD STUDY

"...a survey of the Hebrew word for 'helper' (*ezer*) should caution against using the word itself to support either position... the word *ezer* itself tells us nothing about the status of the individual doing the helping." *Ezer* is the same word used of God himself as Israel's "helper" throughout the Old Testament — it carries no built-in subordination. Sharpens the Genesis 2:24 "oneness" material above, which doesn't otherwise engage the "helper" language directly.

OLD TESTAMENT LAW — REDEMPITIVE THEN, NOT NOW

HEAVY CONTENT — BACKGROUND ONLY, NOT FOR LIVE DELIVERY

Webb, pg. 32: "The first example comes from those Scriptural passages that speak of taking female virgins as spoils of war... Deuteronomy 21:10-14 is at least somewhat redemptive relative to the original culture. After all, the Israelite male had to wait one month, marry the girl, and in the case of divorce he could not sell her or treat her as a slave... Compared to the horrible rape scenes that often accompanied ancient warfare... these biblical texts are clearly redemptive." Included because it's Webb's starkest example of the "doubleness" concept — genuinely redemptive in its own era, genuinely hard to read today — but not something for the room. The Deuteronomy 25 levirate marriage example above makes the same point without this content.

WEBB, PG. 77 — THE DAUGHTERS OF ZELOPHEHAD

"The daughters of Zelophehad courageously asked to inherit their family land in view of their father dying without any sons... In essence they pushed the boundaries of patriarchy as it related to land inheritance. Ultimately, these rights were granted to them... it is an indication of movement in a particular direction."

A positive, low-risk story in its own right (Numbers 27) — five sisters push against inheritance law, and Scripture records God siding with them, granting the change.

WEBB, PG. 78 — BUILT-IN PROTECTIONS IN OT DIVORCE LAW

"Compared to other countries, Israelite males had at least some minimal 'red tape' to work through in divorcing their wives — a bill of divorce had to be written (Deut 24:1-4)... no divorce was ever permitted in either the case of a falsely-charged wife (Deut 22:15) or in the case of violating a virgin (Deut 22:19)... within its own day it granted Israelite women a greater dimension of dignity."

WEBB, PG. 95, 98 — DEBORAH AS A SCRIPTURAL "BREAKOUT"

"...it would seem that God blesses Deborah for her leadership in Israel regardless of her gender, not in spite of her gender... the divine perspective would seem to categorize the standard norms as culturally bound."

Judges 4-5 — judge, elder, prophetess, and military leader, all at once, in a patriarchal era. An Old Testament precedent for the same "breakout" pattern Webb applies to Priscilla (see Segment 2).

THE "DOUBLENESS" OF REDEMPTIVE-ARC PASSAGES

Stackhouse, pg. 86: "Why prefer egalitarian reading to the patriarchal one? Because the egalitarian interpretation makes better sense of the presence of both kinds of texts alongside each other in Scripture. The egalitarian reading does not disrespect traditional reading as if it had no basis in the Bible. It clearly does. But egalitarians see God working through patriarchal structures in Scripture and in church history while also providing the foundation for the removal of those structures when and where the cause of the gospel would be advanced thereby." The named theological label for "doubleness" — a passage can look backward by modern standards while genuinely being elevating for its own time, and that trajectory keeps moving.

FOR FURTHER STUDY — GENDER IN BIBLE TRANSLATION

This is a topic that rewards a closer look. The examples below are from outside reading — not covered live — enough to show there's real substance here, if you want to keep digging after today.

SOURCE: SUZANNE MCCARTHY, *VALIANT OR VIRTUOUS? GENDER BIAS IN BIBLE TRANSLATION*

McCarthy traces how a single Hebrew word — *chayil* (strength, valor, worth) — gets translated very differently in English depending on whether it describes a man or a woman.

PROVERBS 31:10 — "WOMAN OF VALOR"

"Even though this analysis of the Hebrew language is well known to scholars, the woman in Prov 31 is not called a 'woman of valor' in any of the major evangelical Bible translations." (McCarthy, pg. 4)

The Hebrew phrase is *eshet chayil* — the same *chayil* used elsewhere for military valor. Most English translations soften it to "excellent" or "virtuous" wife instead.

GENESIS 39:6 & 29:17 — JOSEPH AND RACHEL, SAME HEBREW WORDS

"When used to describe Joseph, this phrase is usually translated into English as 'handsome and well-built' or 'strong'; however, the Hebrew words are identical to those that are used for Rachel: 'beautiful in form and beautiful in appearance.' The words differ only in their use of the masculine grammatical gender." (McCarthy, pg. 11)

The same underlying Hebrew phrase describes Joseph and his mother Rachel — translated two different ways in English depending on which one is being described. Worth opening your own Bible to both verses and comparing.

CHAYIL, TRACED THROUGH THREE LANGUAGES (MCCARTHY, PG. 5)

Chayil describes only two women in Scripture: Ruth (Ruth 3:11) and the Proverbs 31 wife. It's the same word used for David's mighty men (1 Chronicles 11:10-25) and for Gideon, addressed by the angel of the Lord as a "mighty man of valor" (Judges 6:12). In the earliest Greek translation, both women's *chayil* became *andreia* ("brave, courageous" — from *aner*, "man/warrior"). In Latin, the word then split: Proverbs 31 became *mulier fortis* ("woman of strength"), but Ruth became *virtus* ("virtue") — the same Hebrew word landing in two different places once it passed through Greek into Latin.

McCarthy's book goes well beyond these three examples — this is a partial read, offered here as a starting point, not the full case.

WHERE I LAND

MY OWN SYNTHESIS

Putting all of this together: I don't think the point of this session is to declare the gender debate settled. It's to show the room that Paul was doing something more careful than either "enforce a permanent hierarchy" or "ignore the culture he was writing into." He was working within a real, patriarchal world, protecting the gospel's advance above all else, while planting the actual seeds — mutual submission, Galatians 3:28, Priscilla teaching Apollos and Paul greeting her warmly by name — that keep pointing somewhere past where his own culture could go. Priscilla and Aquila are the living picture of where that trajectory lands: two people who don't fit neatly into a single social category, practicing love and submission toward each other regardless of who held more visible status. That's what I want the room to walk away with — not a verdict on the wider debate, but a model of what it actually looks like lived out.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS — TAKE HOME

ROUND 1 — MEETING PRISCILLA & AQUILA

Has God ever sent you a "Priscilla and Aquila" — someone who showed up right when you needed support most?

ROUND 2 — PRISCILLA, AQUILA, AND APOLLOS

When was a time God spoke to you through an unexpected person?

Optional follow-up: What almost kept you from listening?

ROUND 3 — MARRIAGE, SUBMISSION & ONENESS

We all need to become better at love and submission. Which do you think YOU need to work on?

And who is a good partner to work on this with?

Cedar Mill Bible Church | Men's Breakfast | All Scripture quotations from the ESV unless otherwise noted.